

THE ASHFIELD INHERITANCE

Draft 1 - branching sequence

INT. ASHFIELD MANOR - LIBRARY - DAY

The solicitor reads the will aloud to a room that has not exhaled in several minutes. ELEANOR stands by the window. Her brother THOMAS does not look at her once. When the solicitor reaches the clause about the estate, Eleanor finally turns around.

SOLICITOR

The whole of it. To the younger sister.

THOMAS

Read it again.

Eleanor can go straight out to the stables and have it out with Thomas where nobody will overhear, or she can walk down to the cottage first and hear what the tenants already know.

STABLES CONFRONTATION

EXT. THE STABLES - CONTINUOUS

Thomas is already saddling a horse he has no intention of riding. Two-day shoot on this one - we need the argument covered across both an overcast morning and the golden hour, or the cut won't hold together.

THOMAS

You knew. All that time sitting with him, you knew.

ELEANOR

I sat with him because nobody else would.

THE TACK ROOM

EXT. THE STABLES - LATER

Eleanor finds the ledgers exactly where her father said they would be, behind the feed bins. One-day shoot for this one - we only need the one angle on the ledgers coming out.

She reads standing up, in the cold, for a long time.

THE LONG GALLERY

INT. THE LONG GALLERY - LATER

Eleanor walks the length of it alone, past every portrait of every man who has ever owned this house. One-day shoot here, but we need the full length of the room in one unbroken take.

She stops at the last frame, which is still empty.

BURNING THE LETTER

INT. THE LONG GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

She holds the solicitor's letter over the candle without letting it catch, and stands there long enough that the wax runs down onto the sill.

DEPARTURE

EXT. ASHFIELD MANOR - DRIVE - DAWN

The trunk is loaded before anyone else is awake. Eleanor does not look back at the house, and whatever the letter said, it goes with her. The sequence ends here.

CHURCHYARD

EXT. ST. ALDATE'S CHURCHYARD - DAY

She reads the letter aloud to a headstone, once, and then puts it away for good. Whatever comes after this is not part of this sequence.

COTTAGE VISIT

INT. THE COTTAGE - DAY

Eleanor ducks under the low beam and finds the tenants already halfway through packing. Nobody here is surprised to see her, which tells her more than the will did.

COTTAGE REFUSAL

INT. THE COTTAGE - CONTINUOUS

She offers them the tenancy in writing and they refuse it in writing, and that is the end of that. The sequence ends here.